

Fear can facilitate acceptance of extraordinary measures

Emotions - viewed as appraisals - can be seen as 'judgements' or 'evaluations' of a particular state of affairs.

i.e., when I feel fear, I judge something to be fearsome.

As a response to a supposed threat, fear facilitates tacit acceptance of security framing, and the policy proposals it entails.

→ For instance, feeling fear in response to migration legitimises the threat as 'fear worthy', moving the issue into the realm of 'panic politics'. This emotional judgement predisposes audiences to accept extraordinary policy responses.

Notably, emotions do not need to be conscious or intentional in order to "tinge our intellectual beliefs and judgements". Most often, fear is used to cultivate audience acceptance of extraordinary or 'crisis' policy responses (securitization).



Source: Van Rythoven, 2015, p. 459

[Learning to feel, learning to fear? Emotions, imaginaries, and limits in the politics of securitization - Eric Van Rythoven, 2015](#)

How to use this card

You can use these cards to come up with new ideas.

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Fear cannot coexist with empathy

Fear - the key emotion which facilitates tacit acceptance of security framings and predisposes audiences to emergency measures - cannot coexist with empathy towards the same object.

→ If policy actors successfully cultivate empathy within audiences for a particular group, this prevents those audiences from seeing this group as a threat - preventing extraordinary measures from being accepted under security framings.

For this reason, fear and empathy-based framings have been found to compete with one another in the European Parliament.



Source: Sanchez Salgado, R. M. (2021)

[Emotions in the European Union's decision-making: the reform of the Dublin System in the context of the refugee crisis.](#)

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Shaming can lead to compliance or trigger shaming backlash

Policymakers or interest groups will often attempt to shame others into compliance with their own policy framings & proposals. These shaming attempts can be normative (based on universal values), disciplinary (based on order, authority and dependance), or policy (based on ideology, national identity, and partisan).

Normative shaming is most effective when the shamer and the audience share a conception of right and wrong. Shame backlash - where shame is redirected onto the shamer - is most common in normative shaming, when the powerless seek change from the powerful, or when the shaming comes from an 'outsider'.



Source: Sanchez Salgado, R.M., 2023.

[The many faces of the politics of shame in European policymaking](#)

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Collective emotions are influenced by cultural context

The appropriate emotional responses to certain situations are learned. → e.g., a child learns to feel sombre in response to a war memorial by observing others.

Collective emotions are those which we have learned to feel in response to familiar cultural narratives, symbols, tropes or collective memories.

When applied to security issues, these narratives, symbols, and tropes can be referred to as the 'local security imaginary' which determines what inspires fear in audiences, what is viewed as a threat or vulnerability, and how these threats/vulnerabilities are articulated.

Threats often only 'resonate' within audiences if they evoke collective fears from the local security imaginary.



Source: Van Rythoven, 2015

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Bias and assumptions influence 'collective fears'

Since collective fears are the those “which audiences have already learned to fear or imaginably foresee fearing” (Van Rythoven, 2015), these learned fears can also be shaped by social bias.

For example, within security discourse on migration, securitizing actors often construct a racialized, masculinised threat (Auchter, 2025). Conversely, when migrants are presented as vulnerable, they are characterised as ‘women and children’ (Carpenter, 2005).

Considering the power of unconscious bias, and the fact that unintentional emotional appraisals can “tinge our intellectual beliefs and judgements” (Van Rythoven, 2015), the role of bias and assumptions should be scrutinised when it comes to judging threats in politics and policymaking.



Source: Van Rythoven, 2015

[Learning to feel, learning to fear? Emotions, imaginaries, and limits in the politics of securitization - Eric Van Rythoven, 2015](#)

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If only institutions are treated as sacred, what happens to the dignity of the living?

Durkheim demonstrated how societies define what is “sacred” through shared rituals. Goffman argued that even the self deserves ritual respect. But not everyone receives that respect in public life.

When grief erupts in working-class or racialised communities, it’s often seen as disruption, not mourning.

Whose emotions are granted legitimacy in our democracies and whose are silenced?



Policy that ignores whose pain is legitimised and whose is ignored deepens moral inequality. Emotional justice demands symbolic reform.

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Embarrassment isn't weakness. It's structural violence in disguise.

Goffman called embarrassment a failure in the “ritual order”, when someone can't meet society's emotional expectations. But in unequal systems, those expectations are rigged. The poor, disabled, or marginalised are shamed simply for not performing the “right” emotions (dignity, control, politeness).



*“So, does anyone else feel that
their needs aren't being met?”*

*Policy shouldn't police emotions. It should dismantle the systems
that make dignity a privilege.*

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Collective effervescence can unite but also ignite

Durkheim believed that rituals generate emotional energy that lifts people beyond themselves.

But Collins warned that this energy can divide just as powerfully: bonding “us” by defining “them.”

From nationalist rallies to violent protests, the same emotional fuel can build community or burn bridges.

Policy must distinguish between rituals that empower and those that exclude or inflame.



Durkheim on collective effervescence: *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*. Translated by Karen E. Fields, Free Press, 1995.

Collins on emotional energy and in-group/out-group dynamics: *Interaction Ritual Chains*. Princeton University Press, 2004 & "Rituals of Solidarity and Security in the Wake of Terrorist Attack." *Sociological Theory*, vol. 22, no. 1, 2004, pp. 53–87.

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No ritual, no recognition

Randall Collins showed that emotional energy, the glue of social solidarity, comes from shared rituals: being physically present, focused, and included.

When communities are denied public spaces, mourning rituals, or cultural gatherings, they're denied emotional visibility.



Governments and NGOs must fund and protect community rituals, not just gather feedback. Visibility needs infrastructure.

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In rituals of proximity, fear is infectious

Emotional contagion spreads fastest in tight spaces, especially when symbols and meaning break down.

During pandemics, wars, or crises, fear thrives when people are close but confused, physically near, symbolically unanchored.



Crisis policy must prioritise emotional clarity and symbolic safety, not just logistics.

Collins on bodily co-presence and emotional contagion: *Interaction Ritual Chains*. Princeton University Press, 2004.

On fear contagion in public health and crisis contexts: Strong, Philip. "Epidemic Psychology: A Model." *Sociology of Health & Illness*, vol. 12, no. 3, 1990, pp. 249–259 & Ahmed, Sara. *The Cultural Politics of Emotion*. Routledge, 2004.

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Politics runs on emotional masks

Goffman showed that public life is performance. We wear emotional “masks” to play our roles.

In politics, this can mean empathy is staged and outrage is calculated.

When feelings become strategy, the public risks being manipulated instead of heard.

Institutions must guard against emotional performance that hides real issues or distorts consent.



Goffman on dramaturgy and emotional masks: *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. Anchor Books, 1959.

On performativity and emotional scripts in politics: Hochschild, Arlie Russell. *The Managed Heart: Commercialization of Human Feeling*. University of California Press, 1983 & Wedeen, Lisa. *Ambiguities of Domination: Politics, Rhetoric, and Symbols in Contemporary Syria*. University of Chicago Press, 1999.

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The power of moral emotions

Moral emotions are emotions linked to societal concerns.

These emotions serve as affective signals of prosocial behavior and play a central role in influencing group-oriented thought and attitudes.



POWER OF EMOTIONS IN MOBILISING FOR SOCIAL & POLITICAL CHANGE



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POWER OF EMOTIONS IN FUELLING ANTI-DEMOCRATIC MOVEMENTS

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Can you feel it?

Many people shy away from political discussions to avoid emotional arguments, while others feel overwhelmed by the increasing emotional tone of political discourse.



The more people **disconnect** from politics, the easier it becomes for **emotional narratives** to take over.

Overemotionalised political discourse can deepen divisions, turn political debates into **identity wars**, and ultimately **stall policymaking**.

Source: MORES Horizon Europe Project



Funded by
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Emotions & Policy Making

Integrating collective emotions into the policymaking process is complex but essential, especially in issues involving identity, crisis, trauma, or social justice.

Effective Strategies:

1. Deliberative public engagement (e.g. citizen assemblies, crowdsourcing, etc.)
2. Emotive framing in policy communication
3. Emotional impact assessments

To avoid:

1. Over-rationalisation
2. Emotion manipulation/exploitation
3. Assuming emotional homogeneity (one-size-fits-all)

Recommendations:

- Training
- Use emotion data
- Build feedback loops, not just one-off consultations



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dreamocracy

Who gets to feel in politics?

Emotions in policymaking aren't gender-neutral. Studies show that female politicians face obstacles in showing assertive emotions such as anger or pride, while men are encouraged to express them and are socially rewarded for it. This emotional double standard reproduces gendered power hierarchies and limits who gets to be heard.

This imbalance weakens democratic deliberation by making emotions gender-exclusive. Gender equality trainings can help create policy making environments where all voices and emotional expressions are equally valid.



Shields, S. A. (2005) The Politics of Emotion in Everyday Life: "Appropriate" Emotion and Claims on Identity" <https://doi.org/10.1037/1089-2680.9.1.3>

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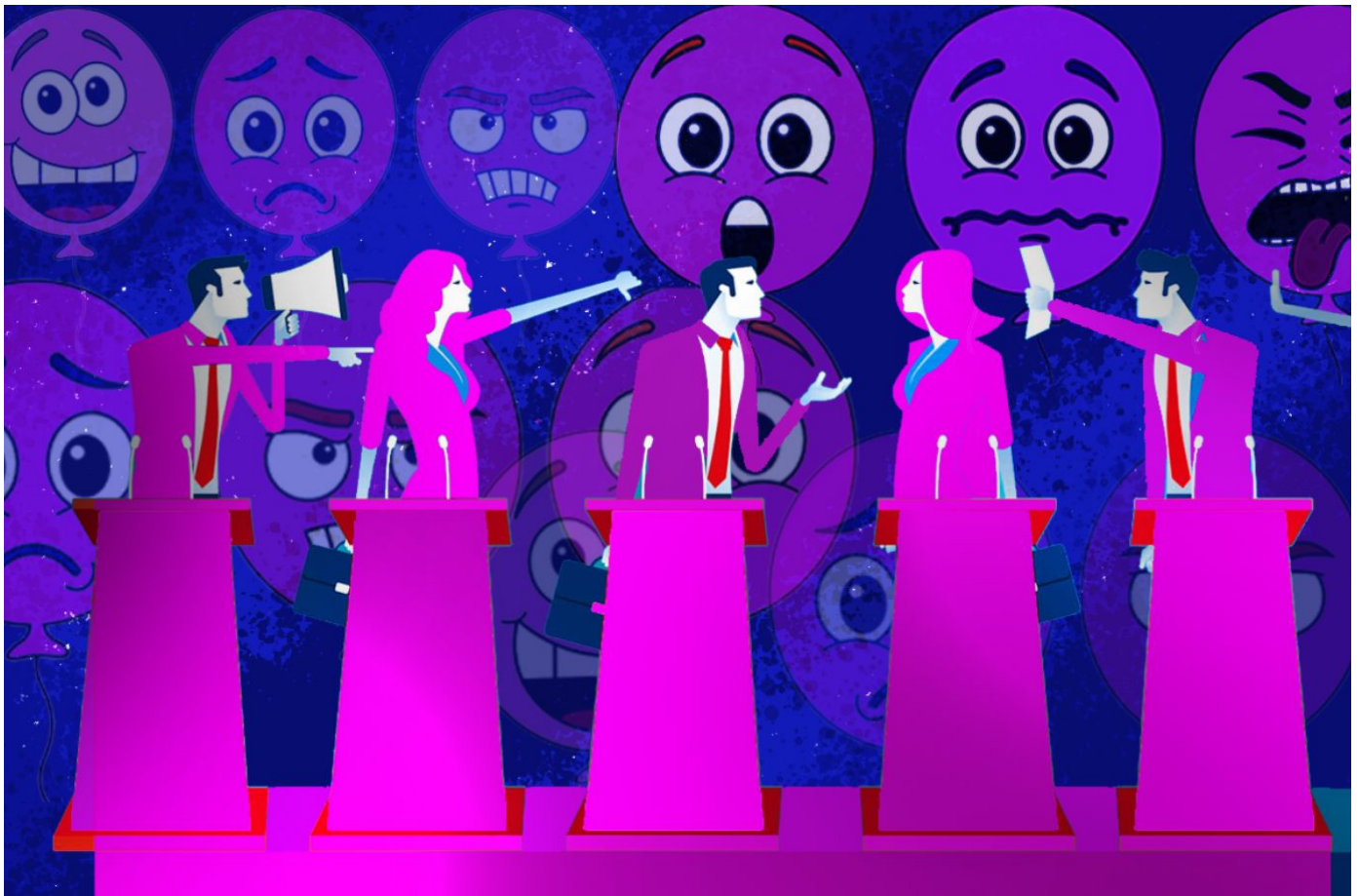
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Emotional Double Standards

Displaying emotions in politics is a balancing act. Assertiveness and pride are framed as leadership traits, while care and vulnerability are often dismissed as emotional excesses, especially when expressed by women. These emotional framings reinforce stereotypes that masculine emotions equate to competence, while feminised emotions are dismissed.



Eagly, A. H. & Karau, S. J. (2002) Role congruity theory of prejudice toward female leaders.
<https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-295X.109.3.573>

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Emotions as Strategy - Not Weakness

Emotions can also be a strategic tool in policymaking. Female politicians often use emotions to appeal to solidarity and collective responsibility during times of crises, especially in areas like health, care, and equality.

Emotions can build solidarity and resilience and recognising them can expand democratic discourse.



Whittier, N. (2021) How emotions shape feminist coalitions.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/13505068211029682>

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Silent Emotions, Silenced Voices

Silencing is emotional too. When female politicians are interrupted or ignored, their emotions aren't just personal, they are also political. Their suppressed emotions mark the limits of equal participations.

Silencing also limits the diversity of perspectives in political deliberation. Promoting equal speaking time can bring more equal participations across genders.



Vallejo Vera, S. & Gomez Vidal, A. (2020) The Politics of Interruptions. Gendered Disruptions of Legislative Speeches.
<https://doi.org/10.1086/717083>

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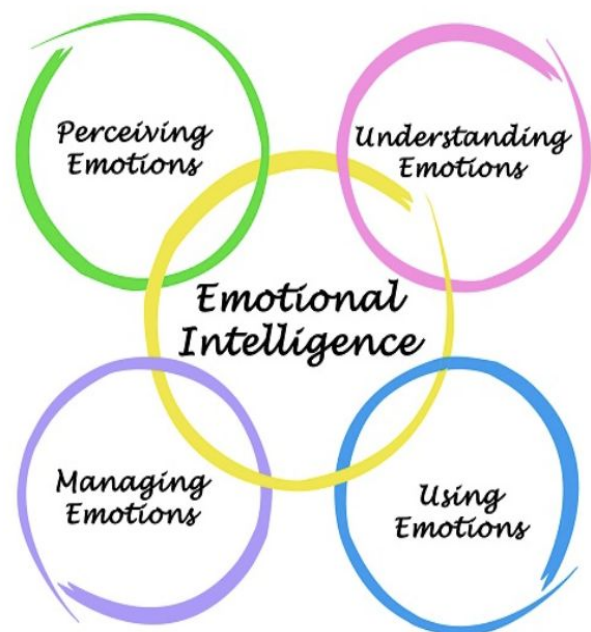
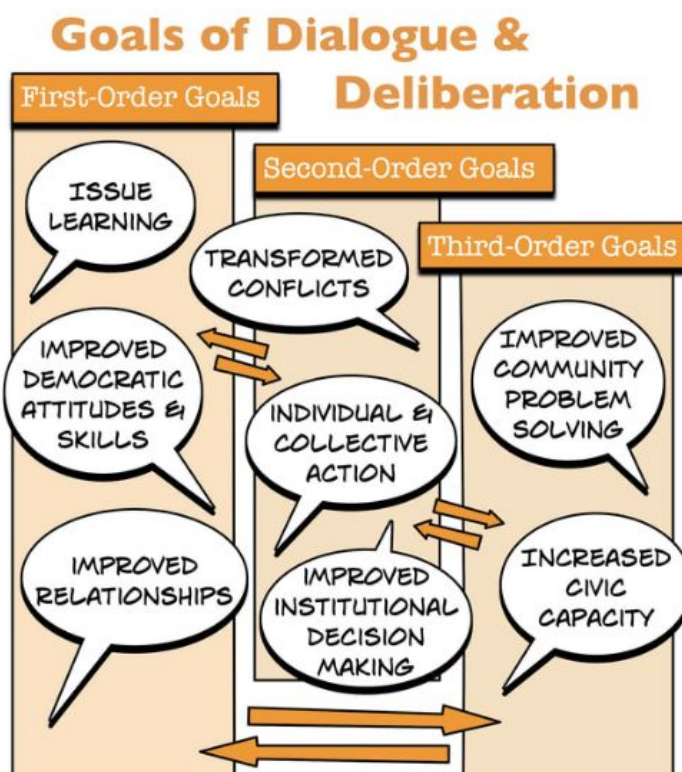
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Emotional Diversity can bring better policies

Research shows that emotional diversity in deliberation improves outcomes. When all genders can express their emotions freely, discussions become more inclusive and policies more empathetic.

Emotionally inclusive practices improve trust, participation, and legitimacy in democratic processes.



Morell, M. E., Johnson, G. F. & Black, L. W. (2022) Mini-Public Replication: Emotions and Deliberation in the Citizens' Initiative Review Redux.
<https://doi.org/10.16997/jdd.1043>

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